

**PRECISION AT WORK** Surgeons performing microscopic spine surgery at Artemis Hospital, Gurugram

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

**"In the past decade, spine surgery has changed in ways once thought impossible. Robot-assisted procedures allow millimetre-level accuracy. This lowers nerve risks and speeds recovery"**

**DR HITESH GARG,** *Head of Ortho-spine Surgery, Artemis Hospital, Gurugram*

Acupuncture—a traditional Chinese medicine practice that involves inserting thin needles into specific points on the body—is increasingly integrated into rehab programmes. "It can't realign bones, but it can relax muscles, improve blood flow and reduce inflammation," says Dr Raman Kapur, head of acupuncture at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, New Delhi. Often paired with postural retraining, core strengthening, stretching and physiotherapy, acupuncture offers a supportive, low-risk way to manage mild spinal misalignments and related discomfort.

But, sometimes, the pursuit of health can backfire. During the pandemic, 28-year-old Delhi resident Priya Malhotra began following online yoga tutorials without supervision. Attempting advanced backbends and twists, she developed a sharp lower back pain. "I thought yoga was always safe, so I ignored the warning signs," she says. But an MRI eventually revealed lumbar strain with early disc changes. Finally, months of physiotherapy and guided training helped her recover.

To prevent such setbacks, experts emphasise awareness. "There's no single perfect posture," says Dr Kapur. "What matters is a dynamic, balanced lifestyle that keeps the spine supported, strong and mobile." Dr Mathai advocates a holistic approach that emphasises prevention. Ergonomic chairs with lumbar support, medium-firm mattresses and pillows that preserve the neck's natural curve can ease everyday strain. Regular walking, swimming and supervised yoga help strengthen and align the spine, while timely medical intervention for pain can prevent chronic complications.

Education, especially in childhood, is crucial. Dr Chhabra stresses that teaching correct posture and load-bearing habits early is far more effective than correcting them later. Limiting schoolbag weights, enforcing screen-time rules and encouraging outdoor play can dramatically reduce long-term risk. Communities must also be trained to spot red flags like weakness, numbness or persistent pain that signal the need for urgent care.

On the policy side, Dr Chhabra, who also chairs the National Academy of Medical Sciences Taskforce on Spine Care, calls for nationwide adoption of the WHO's 2023 guidelines on chronic low back pain, workplace ergonomics incentives and broader insurance coverage for non-surgical care. District-level rehab units and outcome tracking, he argues, would improve both access and quality.

With education, policy reform and medical innovation working together, spine care in India is at a turning point. What was once a hidden epidemic of pain could become a model of proactive health, accessible care and longer, healthier lives. ■